

Build a Business That Runs Smoothly

Operations

Book 8



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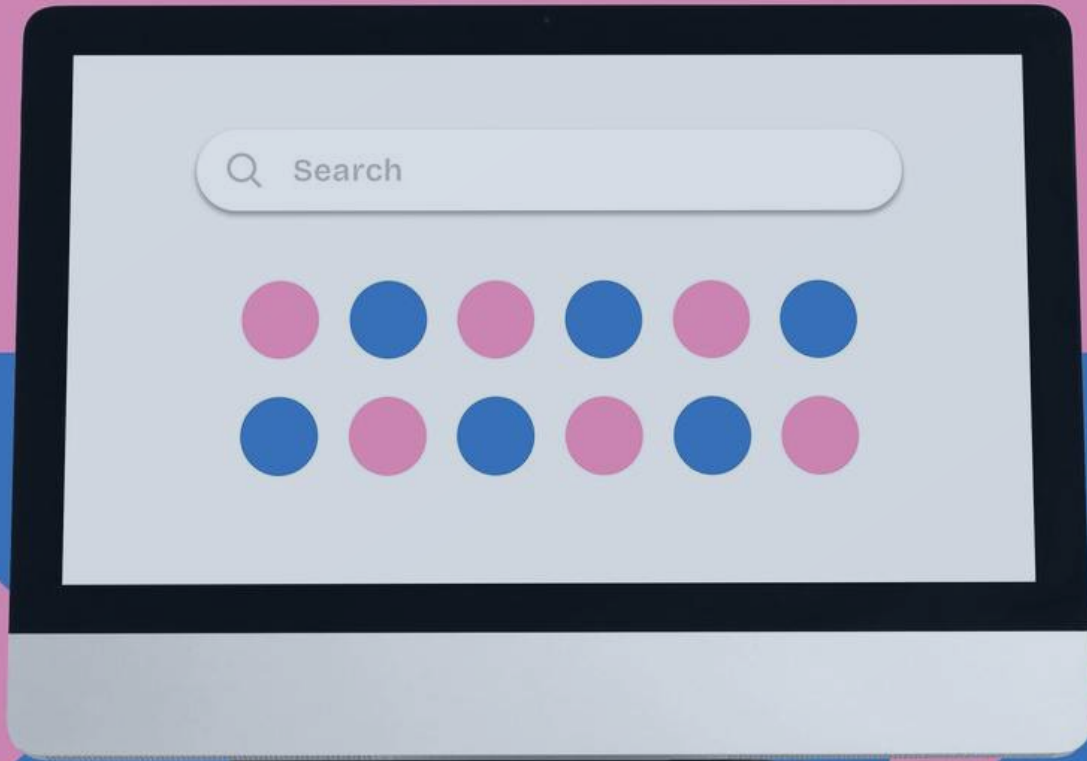
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Creating SOPs

Documenting how things get done.

Chapter 1

Documenting how things get done.

An SOP is a written way of saying: "This is how we do this task every time." That's it.

An SOP is not: a big binder, a corporate manual, fancy language, or complicated. An SOP is simply written clarity. If a task matters, it should not live in your head, in someone's memory, or in "how we usually do it." It should live on paper (or a doc).

What This Means

An SOP formalizes the best known way to perform a task so that anyone on the team can execute it the same way, every time. This is how you scale without diluting quality: you replace tribal knowledge with written clarity. If a task matters, it gets captured and shared. That is the cultural shift SOPs create.

If your business only works when you're present, you don't have operations. You have babysitting.

Without SOPs: work quality changes, employees guess, mistakes repeat, training takes forever, you answer the same questions daily, and growth feels painful. With SOPs: work becomes predictable, training is faster, quality improves, and you stop being the bottleneck. SOPs are how you replace you with process.

Example: A Residential Cleaning Business

The owner cleans homes: kitchens, bathrooms, bedrooms, living areas. At first, they do everything themselves. Then they hire help. This is where things break. Without SOPs: one cleaner misses details, another cleans differently, customers complain, owner re-cleans homes. That's not a people problem. That's an SOP problem.

- One cleaner misses details
- Another cleans differently
- Customers complain
- Owner re-cleans homes

What an SOP Actually Looks Like

An SOP answers three questions:

1) What is the task?

2) How do we do it?

3) What does “done right” look like?

That’s it. Keep it short, clear, and repeatable.

Example SOP: Cleaning a Bathroom. Task: Clean bathroom. Steps: Wipe mirror, Clean sink, Scrub toilet, Clean shower, Mop floor. Standard: No streaks, No hair, No smell. Simple. Clear. Repeatable.

Which Tasks Need SOPs First

Not everything needs an SOP on day one. Start with tasks that are: repeated often, easy to mess up, customer-facing, important to quality. For the cleaning business: kitchen cleaning, bathroom cleaning, how to enter a home, how to lock up, how to report issues. These are high-impact tasks.

How SOPs Actually Help (Cleaning Example)

Before SOPs: cleaner asks questions constantly, owner checks every job, quality is inconsistent, stress is high. After SOPs: cleaner follows steps, quality stays consistent, owner checks less, customers are happier. The work didn’t change. The clarity did.

What NOT to Do

Don’t overcomplicate SOPs. Don’t write for perfection. Don’t document everything at once. Don’t use big words. Don’t hide SOPs. Don’t ignore updates. An SOP should be easy to read, easy to follow, easy to update. If no one uses it, it’s useless.

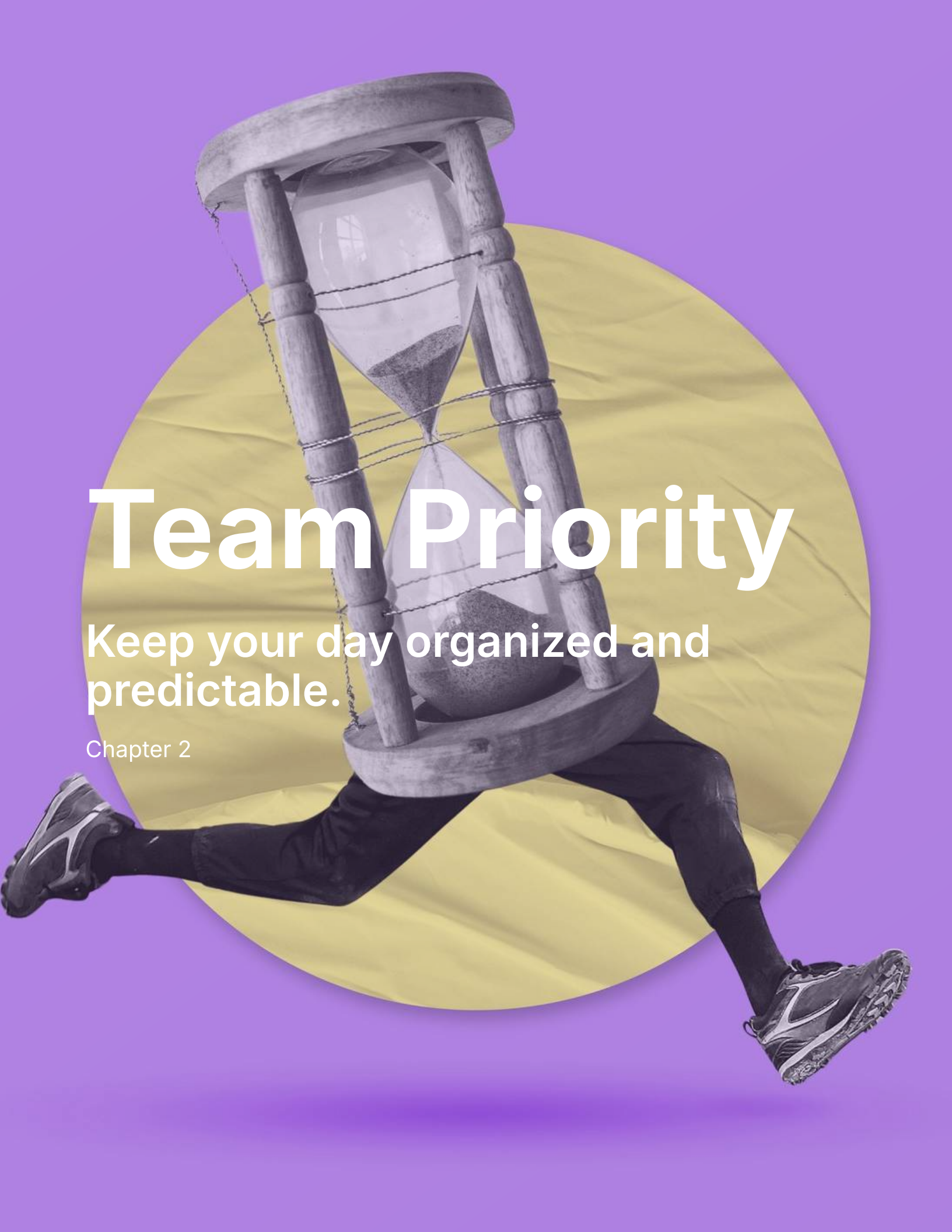
Example: Putting It All Together

The cleaning business creates SOPs for: bathrooms, kitchens, entry and exit, supplies used. Now: new hires learn faster, work is consistent, fewer complaints, owner steps back, business runs smoother. SOPs don't slow you down. They remove friction.

One-Sentence Summary: "SOPs turn chaos into consistency."

Quick Recap:

SOPs document how work gets done. They replace memory with clarity. Start with repeatable, high-impact tasks. Keep them simple. Use them for training and quality. SOPs let the business run without you. If a task matters, it deserves an SOP.

A conceptual image featuring a person in black athletic wear and grey sneakers running from left to right. On their back is a large, rustic wooden hourglass. The hourglass has two glass bulbs connected by a narrow neck, with dark sand visible inside. It is held together by several thin metal wires. The person is running against a solid purple background, with a large, bright yellow circle behind them, partially obscured by the hourglass.

Team Priority

Keep your day organized and
predictable.

Chapter 2

Keep your day organized and predictable.

A daily priority list tells you what matters today. A staff checklist tells your team what must be done every time. Together, they answer two simple questions:

What do we need to do today? How do we know it's done right?

This is how you stop reacting all day and start running the business on purpose.

Why This Matters

If everything is a priority, nothing is. Without daily priorities and checklists: days feel chaotic, important tasks get skipped, small things get forgotten, mistakes repeat, and you spend the day firefighting.

Most owners say: “I’m busy all day but nothing gets done.” That’s not a work problem. That’s a priority problem.

Example — A Lawn Care Business With Weekly Routes

The business mows lawns Monday–Friday, with multiple homes per day, same service over and over, crews in the field, and tight schedules. It’s the perfect example of why daily priorities and checklists matter: repetition, logistics, and customer expectations collide daily.

Daily Priority Lists: For the Owner or Manager

A daily priority list is not a long to-do list. It should include only what truly matters today. Beginner rule: No more than 3–5 priorities per day.

Example daily priorities (lawn care owner): 1) Confirm today’s route is correct. 2) Make sure crews have equipment and fuel. 3) Handle customer schedule changes. 4) Review yesterday’s issues. 5) Check that payments were processed. If these get done, the day is a win.

Staff Checklists: For the Team

Staff checklists remove guessing. For lawn care crews, a daily checklist might include: Load mower, Load trimmer, Load blower, Check fuel, Review route, Confirm first address. Job-site checklist: Mow evenly, Edge sidewalks, Trim borders, Blow clippings, Close gates. Checklists turn “do your best” into do it this way.

Why Checklists Work (Lawn Care Example)

Before checklists: crews forget tools, jobs get rushed, customers complain, owner gets calls. After checklists: crews follow the same steps, quality stays consistent, fewer mistakes, fewer interruptions. The checklist becomes the boss — not you

How to Build Simple Checklists

Keep them short, clear, in order, and easy to check off.

Bad checklist: paragraphs, vague instructions, too many steps. Good checklist: short action items, clear outcomes, repeatable. If it's hard to follow, it won't get used. Consistency beats intensity.

What NOT to Do

Don't rely on memory. Don't overload daily priorities. Don't assume people "know." Don't change priorities constantly. Don't skip review. Build a rhythm: plan, execute, review, improve. This habit compounds into calmer days and stronger performance.

Final Example: Putting It All Together

The lawn care business uses daily priority lists for planning, staff checklists for execution, and reviews issues at the end of the day. Now: days feel calmer, crews work faster, quality improves, owner steps back, business becomes predictable. Operations stop living in your head and start living on paper.

One-Sentence Summary: "Daily priorities focus the day checklists protect the work."

Quick Recap: Daily priorities define what matters today. Limit priorities to 3–5 items. Staff checklists remove guessing. Checklists create consistency. Predictable days come from clear systems. Busy is not the goal. Predictable is.



Vendors & Contracts

Tools that make working with others easier.

Chapter 3

Tools that make working with others easier. Vendors and contractors are people you pay to help your business run. Examples include suppliers, freelancers, subcontractors, maintenance companies, and specialists you don't hire full time.

Contracts are simple documents that say: what work is being done, who is responsible for what, how much it costs, when it gets paid, and what happens if something goes wrong.

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Contracts turn verbal agreements into clear expectations.

Why This Matters

If it's not written down, it will be misunderstood.

Most small business owners say: "We agreed on it verbally." "They know what I meant." "We've worked together before." That leads to missed deadlines, surprise charges, quality issues, awkward conversations, and finger-pointing. Templates protect your money, your time, and your relationships. Good operations remove guesswork.

Example — A Property Maintenance Business Using Subcontractors

The business handles small repairs, turnover work, and light maintenance. They hire subcontractors for painting, flooring, and drywall. Without templates: scope changes mid-job, prices creep up, timelines slip, and the owner steps in constantly. That's chaos. With templates, scope and expectations are clear, and everyone moves faster with fewer conflicts.

What a Simple Vendor Template Includes

You do NOT need a legal masterpiece.

A beginner-level template needs only five things:

1) Who is doing the work.

2) What work is included.

3) What work is NOT included.

4) Price and payment terms.

5) Timeline and expectations.

That's it.

Example (painting subcontractor): Work: Paint 2 bedrooms, walls only. Not included: Ceilings, trim, repairs. Price: \$800. Payment: Paid within 5 days of completion. Timeline: Complete in 2 days. Clear beats clever.

How Templates Fix Problems (Maintenance Example)

Before templates: subcontractor says "that wasn't included," owner argues, relationship strains, job delays. After templates: scope is clear, pricing is agreed, fewer surprises, faster work, less stress. The work didn't change. The expectations did.

Why Templates Help Revenue Operations

Vendor chaos affects revenue because delays slow delivery, quality issues hurt customers, rework costs money, and owner time gets wasted. Templates protect margins, speed up delivery, improve consistency, and reduce distractions. Operations stability supports revenue growth by ensuring smooth handoffs and fewer escalations.

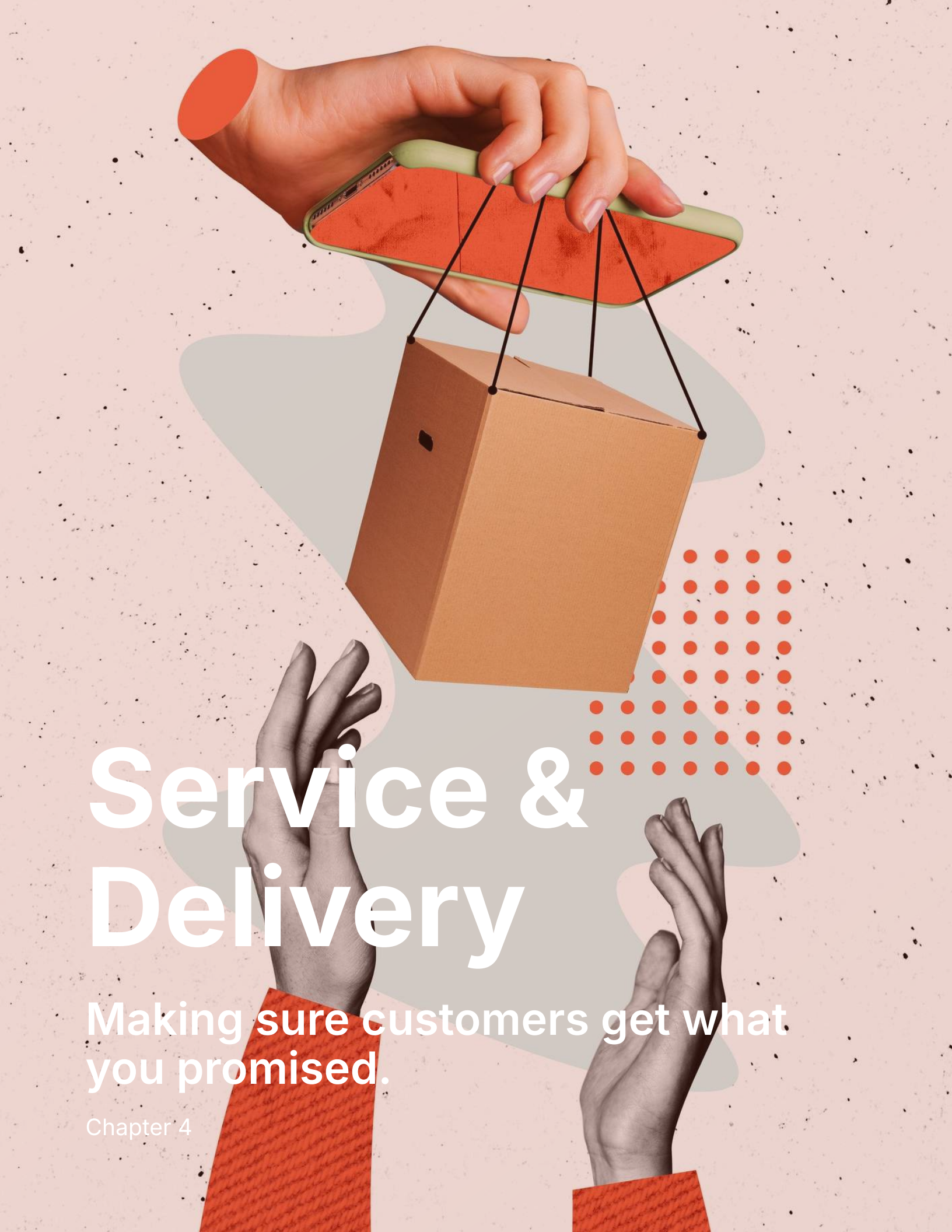
Don't rely on verbal agreements. Don't skip scope details. Don't change terms mid job. Don't pay without clarity. Don't create a new agreement every time.

Repeatable templates equal repeatable results.

Example: Putting It All Together

The maintenance business creates one subcontractor template and one supplier agreement template. Now: jobs run smoother, vendors know expectations, fewer disputes, faster turnaround, owner focuses on growth. Templates don't slow deals down. They prevent problems.

One Sentence Summary: "Templates protect your money, time, and sanity." Quick Recap: Vendors need clarity. Templates set expectations upfront. Keep them simple. Define scope, price, and timeline. Written agreements prevent conflict. Strong operations support revenue. If you work with others, you need templates.

A hand holding a smartphone with a cardboard box hanging from it, and two other hands reaching up towards the box. The background is a light pinkish-grey with a grid of orange dots on the right side.

Service & Delivery

Making sure customers get what you promised.

Chapter 4

Making sure customers get what you promised. Your service or delivery process is the exact path a customer goes through: from “yes,” to work starting, to work finishing, to follow-up.

It answers one simple question: “What happens after someone pays us?” If you don’t define this, every job turns into improvisation.

Why This Matters

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Customers don’t judge you on effort — they judge you on consistency.

Without a clear delivery process: work quality changes, timelines slip, customers get confused, expectations don’t match reality, and complaints increase. Most customer issues are not service issues. They are process issues. A clear delivery process protects customer trust, your reputation, your margins, and your sanity.

Example: A Residential Painting Business

A painting business books jobs weeks in advance, works inside customers’ homes, and deals with timelines, prep, and cleanup. It’s a perfect example because customers expect a clear start and finish, quality matters, and missed steps create frustration fast

What a Simple Delivery Process Looks Like

A beginner-friendly delivery process has five stages:

1) Confirmation

2) Preparation

3) Execution

4) Completion

5) Follow-Up

Each stage reduces uncertainty and aligns expectations for both the team and the customer.

1. Confirmation (Before Work Starts)

This sets expectations. For the painting business: confirm date and time, confirm rooms being painted, confirm price, confirm prep expectations. Example message: "We'll arrive Monday at 8 AM to paint the living room and hallway. Total cost is \$1,200. Please remove wall décor before we arrive." Clarity prevents conflict.

2. Preparation (Before Arrival)

Preparation protects quality. Examples: materials ordered, crew assigned, address confirmed, special notes reviewed. If prep is skipped, execution suffers. A small checklist here can eliminate most day-of surprises.

3. Execution (Doing the Work)

This is where SOPs matter. For painters: protect floors, prep walls, paint in correct order, follow quality standards. Execution should feel boring and repeatable that is the sign of a mature operation.

4. Completion (Wrapping Up)

Never just leave. Completion includes: walkthrough with customer, touch-ups noted, cleanup done, final confirmation. This step prevents callbacks and refunds and converts effort into satisfaction.

5. Follow Up (After the Job)

Follow-up closes the loop: thank-you message, payment confirmation, ask if everything looks good, reminder about warranty or care. Follow-up turns a finished job into a good experience and primes referrals.

What NOT to Do

Don't "wing it" per job. Don't skip confirmation. Don't rush the walkthrough. Don't disappear after payment.

Assume customers don't know what's next. Clear processes beat good intentions every time.

Example: Putting It All Together

The painting business confirms every job, prepares ahead of time, follows the same steps, completes with a walkthrough, and follows up after. Now: fewer complaints, better reviews, higher referrals, less rework, more predictable days. Same service. Better delivery.

One-Sentence Summary: "A clear delivery process turns promises into results." Quick Recap: Delivery is the customer experience. Define what happens after payment. Use confirmation, prep, execution, completion, follow up. Consistency builds trust. Process prevents problems. Customers don't want surprises. They want reliability.

Quality Control

Checking that work meets your standard.

Chapter 5



Checking that work meets your standard.

Quality control is how you make sure the work being done actually matches what you promised.

It answers one simple question: "Did we do this the right way?" Quality control is not micromanaging, hovering, or distrust. It's a simple check to protect your reputation and your revenue.

Why This Matters

If you don't check quality, customers will and they won't be quiet about it. Without quality control: small mistakes get missed, customers notice inconsistencies, complaints increase, refunds happen, reviews suffer, referrals drop.

“

Most quality problems don't come from bad employees. They come from no standard and no checks.

If quality matters, it must be checked.

Example: A Residential Window Cleaning Business

The business cleans exterior windows, interior windows, and screens. Customers expect no streaks, no missed panes, clean edges, and care inside the home. One missed window can ruin the whole job. It's a perfect example for quality control because small defects are highly visible and trust-sensitive.

What Quality Control Looks Like (Beginner Level)

Quality control does not mean redoing the whole job. It means quick checks, clear standards, and catching issues early. For window cleaning, quality checks might include: walk around the house, look for streaks, check corners and edges, confirm screens are clean, and ask, "Would I be happy paying for this?"

When and Who to Check

There are three key moments: during the job, before leaving, and with the customer (if appropriate). Checking early prevents rework later. At first, you (the owner) should perform checks. Later, a lead tech, a supervisor, or a checklist can own it. Quality control should eventually live in the system not just in your head.

Why Quality Control Protects Revenue

Poor quality causes refunds, creates rework, wastes time, hurts reviews, and slows growth. Good quality control protects margins, improves retention, increases referrals, builds trust, and reduces stress. Quality is not a "nice to have." It's a revenue protector.

What NOT to Do

Don't assume work is done right. Don't skip checks to save time.

Don't only check when there's a complaint. Don't be vague about standards. Don't rely on customers to point out mistakes. Quality problems are cheaper to fix before the customer sees them.

Example: Putting It All Together

The window cleaning business uses a simple quality checklist, checks windows before leaving, fixes issues immediately, and confirms satisfaction. Now: fewer callbacks, better reviews, happier customers, more referrals, less stress. Quality control doesn't slow the business down. It keeps it strong.

One-Sentence Summary: "If you don't check quality, you're gambling with your reputation."

Quick Recap: Quality control checks work against a standard. Small checks prevent big problems. Do checks during and after work. Quality protects revenue and reputation. Systems beat assumptions. You worked hard to win the customer. Don't lose them over something preventable

Simple Interpretation for Small Business Owners

Books 1–3 teach you how to *get customers*.

Books 4–5 teach you how to *keep customers*.

Books 6–8 teach you how to *run the business behind the scenes*.

Book 9 teaches you how to *lead the business like a CEO*.

PHASE 1 — FOUNDATIONS

What you sell, who you sell it to, and how people find you.

1. PRODUCT (Start Here)

Build something people want → understand problem, customer, offer, landscape, MVP.

Unlocks: Marketing + Sales effectiveness.

2. MARKETING

Now that you know your offer and customer → learn to generate leads.

Unlocks: Sales pipeline consistency.

3. SALES

Once leads are coming in → learn to convert them into revenue.

Unlocks: Customer Success workflows and financial predictability.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I have an idea"* → *"I can attract and close paying customers."*

PHASE 2 — DELIVERY SYSTEMS

How you turn customers into raving fans and repeat buyers.

4. CUSTOMER SUCCESS

Once sales convert customers → you learn to onboard, deliver, and retain.

Unlocks: Recurring revenue + testimonials + operational clarity.

5. OPERATIONS

Now you systematize the entire delivery engine: SOPs, checklists, templates, processes.

Unlocks: Quality control, scalability, and reduced chaos.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I can sell"* → *"I can consistently deliver and retain."*

PHASE 3 — BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Tools, numbers, and people who make the machine run.

6. TECHNOLOGY

Once operations are forming → you add the tools that support scale (CRM, website, email, payments).

Unlocks: Data visibility, automation, and speed.

7. HUMAN RESOURCES

Once delivery is predictable → you hire and train people to help.

Unlocks: Delegation, team growth, and freeing the founder.

8. FINANCE

Once business grows → you install financial basics (bank accounts, bookkeeping, cash flow, budget, taxes).

Unlocks: Correct pricing, healthy margins, and sustainable growth.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I do everything manually"* → *"My business has real systems and support."*

PHASE 4 — SCALING THE BUSINESS

You become the CEO instead of the operator.

9. GOVERNANCE

Once you have customers, systems, tools, finances, and a team → you implement the rhythms and standards that keep the business aligned.

Includes:

- Comp plans
- Cultural standards
- Planning rhythms
- Promotions/exits
- Decision-making framework

Unlocks:

- True leadership
- Predictable growth
- A business that runs without you

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I built a business"* → *"I operate like a CEO."*

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